

Dear Alexander Buis,

Sustainability-linked equity index development is the focus of my current role as a researcher at Imperial College London, working across labs in the [Leonardo Research Centre on Business for Society](#). The high overlap of Robeco, the indices team and my current role made me genuinely excited to apply.

I have worked on bridging academic research to institutional clients, building sustainability-innovation indices scheduled for public listing in the Japanese market. My research on alpha and sustainability company-maturity signals from text-derived company initiatives, linking corporate actions, SDGs and stakeholders for equity index design, is highly relevant for this role. I have co-authored a working paper, in which financial materiality plays a central role, producing a long-short portfolio with a 1.19 annualised Sharpe ratio and 0.72% monthly FF3 alpha.

During that research we built a modular research pipeline and interactive portfolio-analytics dashboards, which let us inspect the data processing at every step and compare experiments directly. Every run records the code version and data hashes behind it, and we validate that the pipeline reproduces the frozen reference implementation exactly. A published index methodology has to be reproducible years later, which makes a modular, auditable pipeline valuable in an index business. My master's thesis on dynamic equity networks (awarded 93%) is also a strong foundation for portfolio optimisation problems approached through clustering and minimum spanning trees (MST) distances. I presented my thesis at the NetSci conference 2026, to an audience of over 50 professionals.

Jean-Paul van Brakel described the Indices team as functioning "like a start-up", growing from EUR 8B to EUR 110B AuA, while having an academic approach to research. This resonates with me: our Imperial research lab is fast-evolving, highly ambitious, collaborative and entrepreneurial, with an exponential growth mindset, aiming for top clients and journals – a culture where I am already thriving. Speaking with Harald Lohre (Head of Quant Equity Research) on a Teams call, I came to understand what makes Robeco ideal for me: sustainability impact, intellectually demanding work, long-horizon quantitative investing and alternative data, in an academic and friendly culture. That combination is extremely rare and makes me highly motivated to apply. Moreover, I am a resident of Amsterdam, so Rotterdam is a straightforward commute.

This role in the index team is a natural next step in my journey as a quantitative researcher in sustainability equity indices, with the opportunity to bring academic work to an even greater institutional scale, higher collaboration and intellectual evolution.

Kind regards,

Christy Bruce